TallWoodMaker

FREE STARTER LIST

The 10 tools I'd buy again today.

Everything you need to build kitchens, wardrobes and furniture, at home or for paying clients. No workshop required.

Tom Skasko
Woodworker, 15 years of building for clients

10 tools

+ 1 bonus

BEFORE THE LIST

You don’t need a workshop. You need a system.

Most people think furniture starts with a table saw and a big room. It doesn't. The heavy, precise work, cutting panels and gluing edges, is done better and cheaper by a cutting service. Your job is to design it, assemble it and install it. That takes a small kit of good tools.

1

Design it

Plan the piece in software and get an exact parts list. Every measurement decided before you buy a single board.

2

Get it cut & edged

Send the parts list to a cutting service. Panels come back cut to size with the edges already banded.

3

Assemble & install

This is where the 10 tools come in. Build the boxes, hang them, fit them to the room.

> **“That’s all you need to start. Get the panels cut and edged, and with these tools you’ll do good work, as a DIYer and as a pro.”**
>
> Tom, after 15 years of kitchens and wardrobes for clients

Buy good, buy once

Cheap tools cost you twice: once when you buy them, and again in wasted boards and redone work.

One battery system

Pick one brand for all cordless tools. Batteries and chargers then work across everything.

Grow with the jobs

Start with this list. Add a tool only when a real job keeps asking for it.

The list

01 Laser distance measure

Every job starts with measuring, and one wrong number costs you a whole board. A laser is faster than a tape on walls and ceilings, and it never sags.

LOOK FOR A clear, backlit display and a memory for the last readings.

02 Cordless drill driver

The tool you'll pick up most: confirmat screws, hinges, drawer runners, handles. Get it with two batteries, so you never wait for a charge.

LOOK FOR A good clutch, a compact head for tight cabinets, and the battery system you'll stay with.

03 Cordless hammer drill

For the walls. Hanging wall cabinets means drilling into brick and concrete, and with the hammer function it takes seconds instead of minutes.

LOOK FOR The same battery system as your driver, a side handle and a depth stop.

04 Plunge saw with a guide rail

Your panels come pre-cut, but on site you'll still trim a worktop, a filler strip or a plinth. With a rail, that's a clean, straight cut anywhere.

LOOK FOR A rail long enough for a worktop and a splinter guard for clean edges on laminate.

05 Jigsaw

For everything that isn't straight: sink and hob cut-outs, notches around pipes, scribing a panel to a crooked wall.

LOOK FOR Pendulum action, tool-free blade change and fine blades for laminate.

The list

06 Router

Rounded edges, grooves, small fixes on site. The router is what turns a good job into a clean one.

LOOK FOR A plunge base, variable speed and a few quality bits to start.

07 Cordless vacuum

Install day happens in someone's home. Cleaning as you go is what makes people trust you, and it keeps dust out of hinges and runners.

LOOK FOR The same battery system, and a hose that connects to your saw for dust extraction.

08 Sawhorses or a folding work table

Your workshop is wherever you set this up: a garage, a balcony, a client's living room. Panels at working height save your back and your edges.

LOOK FOR Folding, stable, and a top you can clamp to.

09 Good tool cases

Everything has its place, so nothing gets left on site or damaged on the way. Stackable cases are the cheapest way to look like a pro.

LOOK FOR One stackable system, so the cases lock together and carry as one.

10 Transport trolley

Panels, cases and cabinets weigh more than you think. A trolley gets it all from the car to the flat in fewer trips, and keeps your back working for years.

LOOK FOR Folding, big wheels for stairs and kerbs, and a load rating for stacked cases.

+ The 11th tool

+1

Software to design your furniture

The cheapest tool on this list and the one that saves the most money. Design the piece first, get an exact parts list, and send it straight to the cutting service.

MY PICK I built my own: MebCut turns a parts list, even a photo of a handwritten one, into a cutting plan in seconds. Free to start at mebcut.com.

WHAT NEXT

Tools are ready. Now pick your path.

Build at home

Build your own kitchen, step by step.

Measuring, ordering, building the boxes, installing on crooked walls. Plans with cutting lists and drawings from real jobs.

tallwoodmaker.com/build-at-home

Your own shop

Turn it into a workshop that pays.

What to buy next, what to charge and how to find your first clients, from 15 years of running jobs.

tallwoodmaker.com/own-shop

New tricks every week

Real jobs, the decisions behind them and a bit of humor.

@tallwoodmaker

Questions about a tool? Just reply to the email this list came with.